What Separates Profitable NYC Airbnbs from the Rest?

DATA 608 · Story 4 · Analyst view: helping hosts earn more

Tage Singh

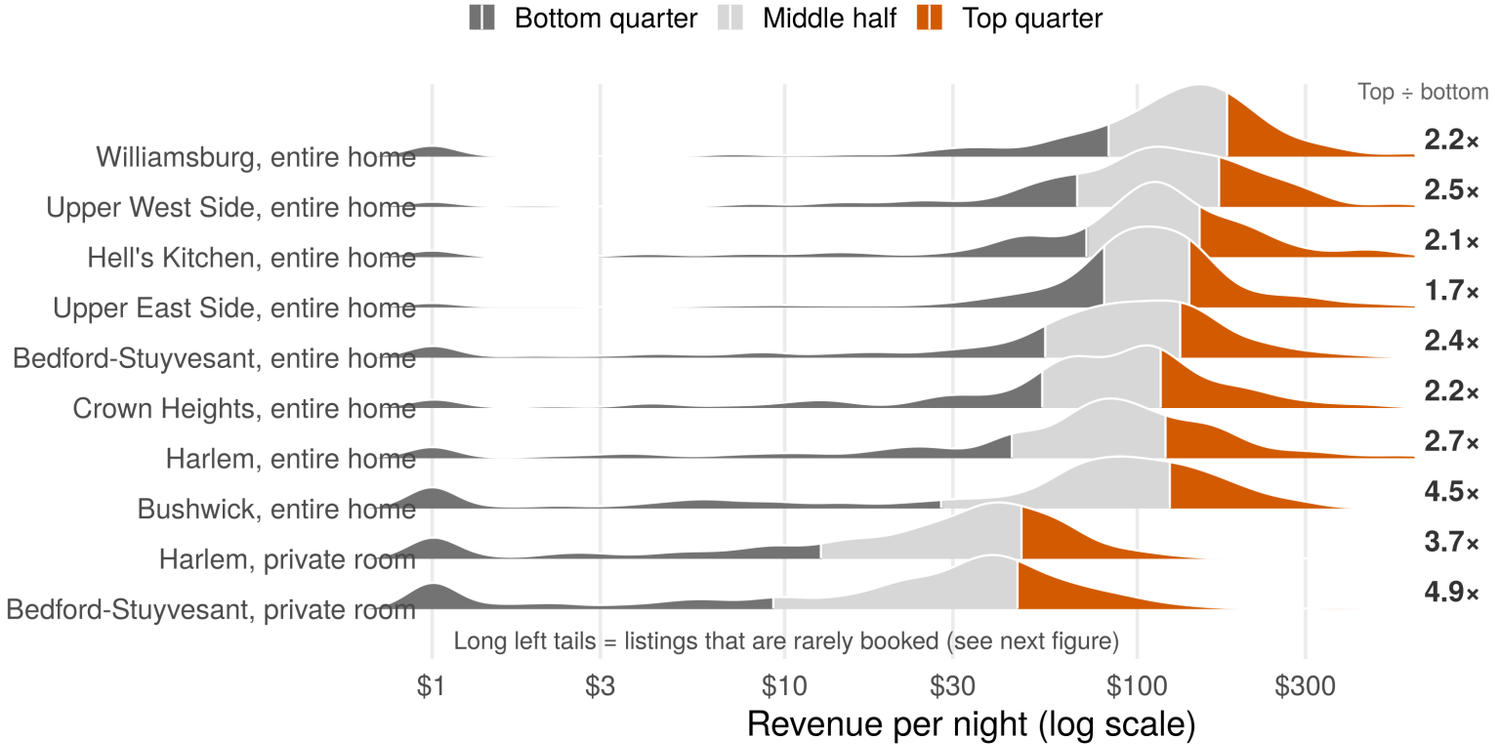
2026-10-25

The short answer

- **Biggest loss:** one in four listings has gone quiet, with median occupancy of 22% vs. 66% for active listings
- **Biggest lever:** three host habits (superhost status, replies within hours, ratings of 4.8+) lift revenue to about 20% above peers
- **Pricing:** entire homes can charge above peers; private rooms priced 25%+ above peers lose half their bookings

Similar listings: the top quarter earns 2.5× the bottom quarter

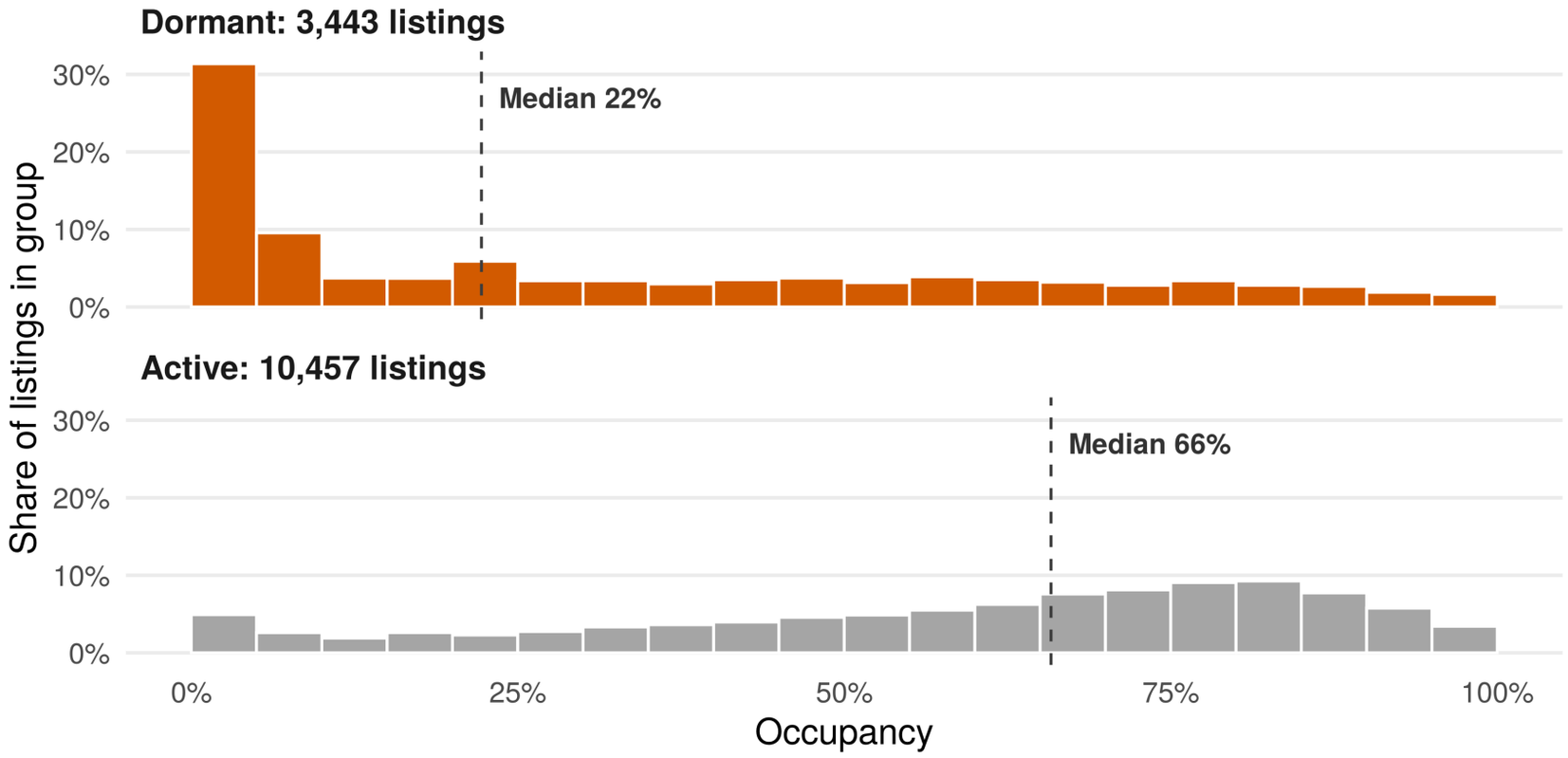
Distribution of revenue per night (price x occupancy) in the ten largest peer groups, all 30+ night stays. Right column: top-quarter cutoff divided by bottom-quarter cutoff.



Peer group = same neighborhood, room type and stay length. Title ratio = median across all peer groups with 15+ listings.
Listings with no booked nights are shown at $1. 353 listings priced above $1,000/night or in shared rooms excluded.
Source: Inside Airbnb NYC listings (course dataset).

One in four listings is dormant and sits empty most of the year

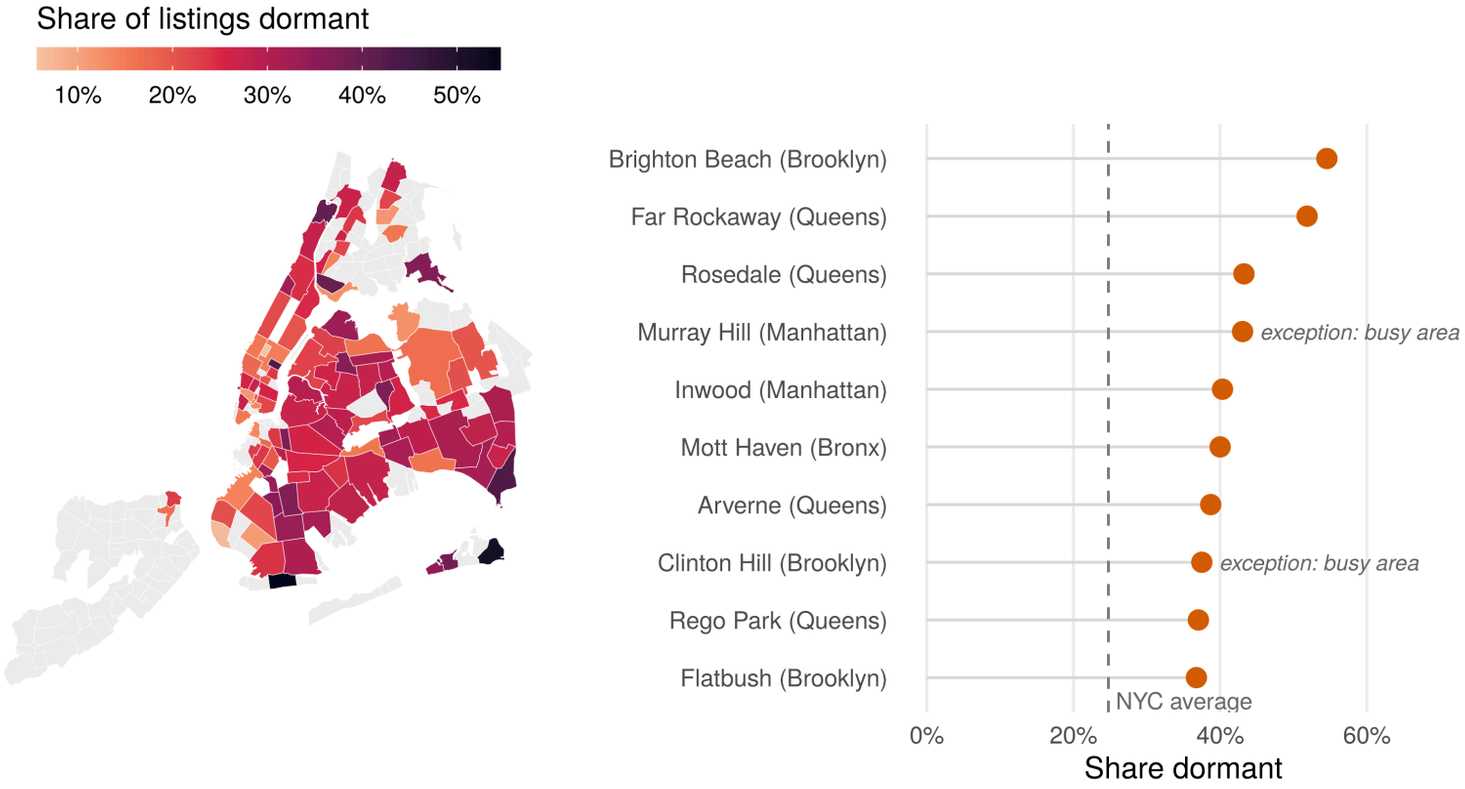
Share of listings at each occupancy level (share of nights booked over the past year)



Dormant = no host response time on record or no reviews in the last 12 months.
Occupancy is modeled from monthly calendar scrapes and is approximate. Source: Inside Airbnb NYC listings (course dataset).

Dormant listings cluster in outer Queens, south Brooklyn, upper Manhattan

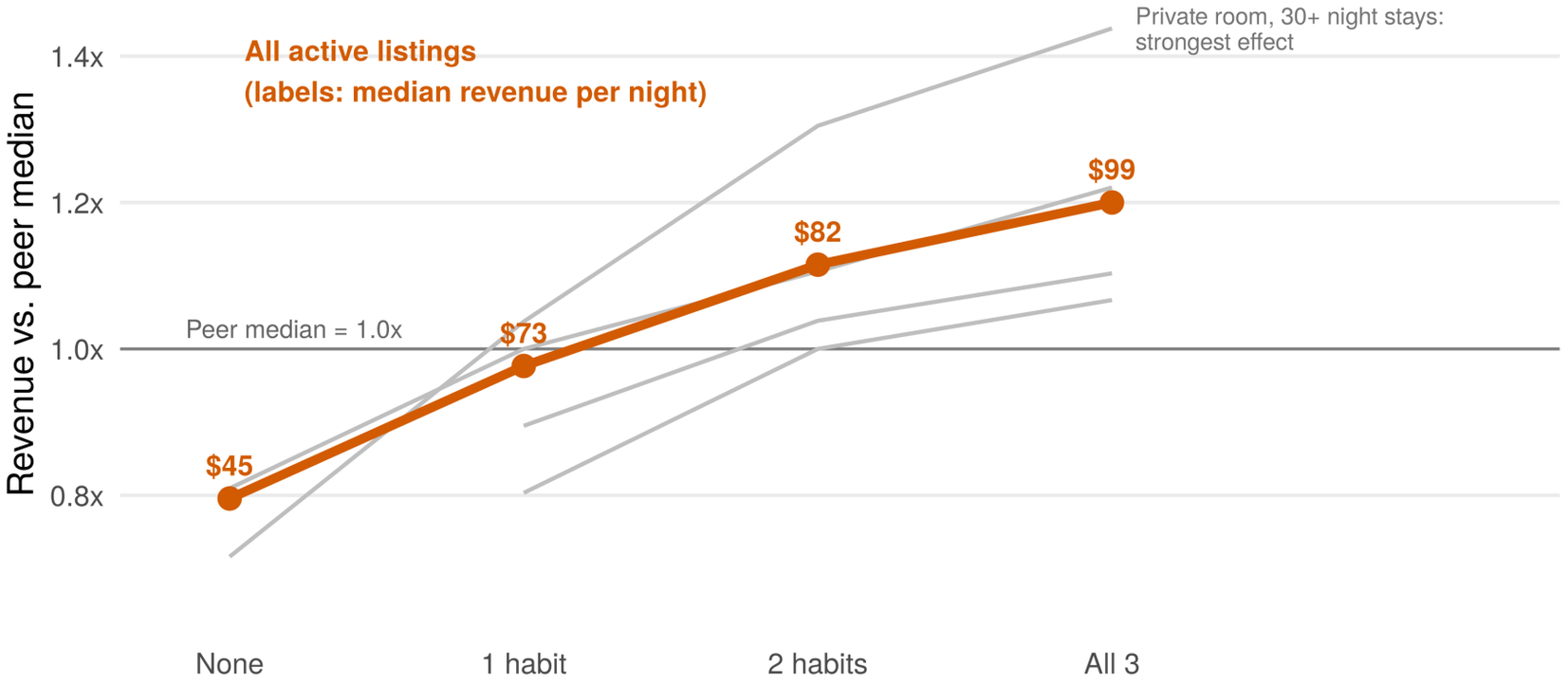
Share of listings that are dormant, by neighborhood (neighborhoods with 20+ listings)



Grey = fewer than 20 listings. Small neighborhoods have noisy shares; the ten highest are listed at right.
Source: Inside Airbnb NYC listings and neighborhood boundaries (course dataset).

Hosts with all three habits earn about 20% above their peers

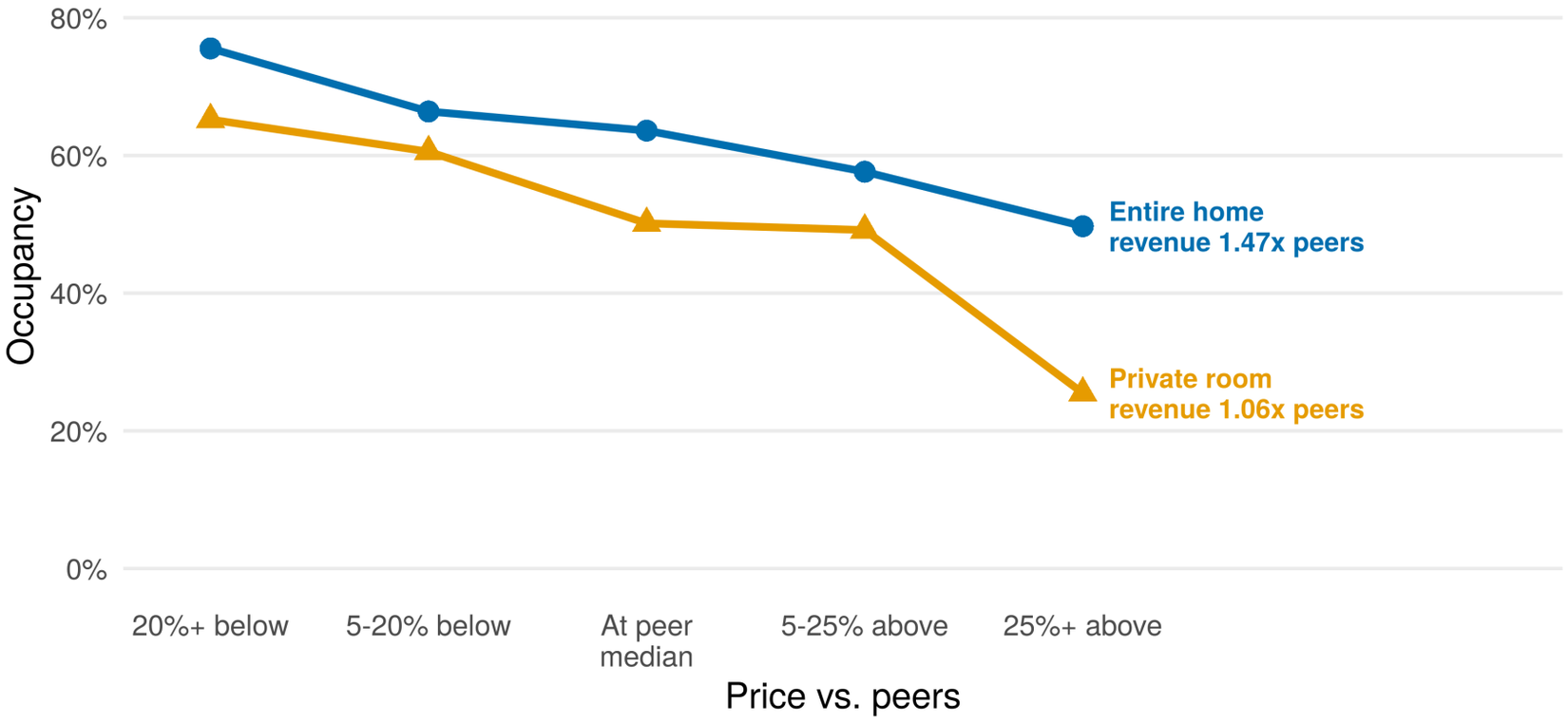
Median revenue vs. the listing's peer group, by number of habits: superhost status, replies within a few hours, guest rating of 4.8 or higher



Active listings in peer groups with 15+ listings. Grey lines = the four room type and stay length segments.
Source: Inside Airbnb NYC listings (course dataset).

Overpriced private rooms sit empty; entire homes can charge more

Median occupancy by price relative to the peer-group median price



Peer groups with 15+ listings. Labels at right: median revenue vs. peers for listings priced 25%+ above peers.
Source: Inside Airbnb NYC listings (course dataset).

Three actions for underperforming hosts, in order of impact

What the data shows for listings that already do each one

Reactivate dormant listings
3,443 listings with no recent reviews or replies

Occupancy 22% to 66% (active median)

Build the three host habits
Active hosts with none or one of the habits

Revenue/night $45 to $99 (+$54)

Price private rooms near peers
Private rooms priced 25%+ above their peers

Occupancy 25% to 50% at peer price

Comparisons are medians for similar listings, not guaranteed results; occupancy is modeled. Source: Inside Airbnb NYC listings (course dataset).

Limitations

- Occupancy is modeled from calendar scrapes, not booking records, so revenue is an estimate
- These are associations, not proven causes: busy listings may earn superhost status and good ratings because they are booked often
- Superhost status and ratings take time to earn; the fastest lever is response time